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Meet Facebook's Solar-Powered Internet-Beaming Drone, Aquila

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Photo: Reuters

Once reaching 1.44 billion (<http://bit.ly/1L22yao>) worldwide active monthly users, what's a social media giant to do? Well, Facebook intends to expand the reach of the Internet, and thereby increase the potential number of users for its ubiquitous service. How, you ask?

The Internet via Lasers

Part of the problem in getting Internet to people in distant, isolated areas of the world is approaching the issue of infrastructure. Running cables can get costly over the great distance between a city center and remote regions. This led engineers to consider a laser communication (<http://bit.ly/1N-lxklM>) and radio frequency technology that can beam a signal over great distances without signal degradation or the need for a massive network of equipment on the ground. Essentially a laser beam could connect otherwise isolated regions to the World Wide Web, and thus Facebook.

An Army of High-Flying Drones

Facebook CEO Mark Zuckerberg announced the ambitious plan on Facebook revealing the news of his futuristic autonomous drones: "As part of our Internet.org effort to connect the world, we've designed unmanned aircraft that can beam Internet access down to people from the sky."

"Codename Aquila, the drone has a wingspan comparable to a Boeing 767 yet uses lightweight materials that allow it to weigh less than a car," reports (<http://tcrn.ch/1L22N5v>) Kyle Russell at TechCrunch. The drone takes its name from the Latin word meaning eagle.

The Aquila drone is designed to remain in flight for as long as 90 days using energy gathered by the solar panels that line its wings. The drones are capable of flying at an altitude of anywhere between 60,000 and 90,000 feet, which puts the flight pattern significantly higher than that used of commercial airline jumbo jets.

Inside Facebook's Connectivity Lab



Takeaway

Much like the Tesla Powerwall (<http://bit.ly/1edlHa9>), Facebook's Aquila drones will jump the curve (<http://bit.ly/1ITyJIK>) in many regions of the world. Some people will never know the telltale sound of a dialup modem connecting to the sluggish Internet we all once knew. Much as some regions will never know electrical power that isn't generated by the sun. Some will only know cell phones and never know the pain of uncoiling a tangled kitchen phone cord.

While Facebook's intention may be to extend the reach of its service and thereby its bottom line, it is a rare instance where self-interest may still help many achieve connectivity to the rest of the world that might have otherwise gone unfulfilled.

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